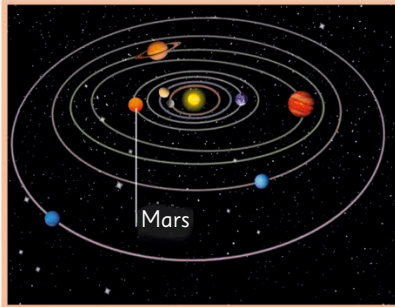
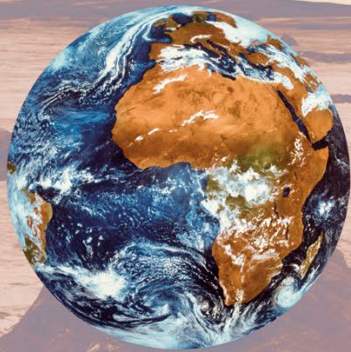




Mars is the fourth planet from the Sun. It has an atmosphere, seasons, huge mountains, and icy poles.

The Red Planet

Mars was named by the Romans after their god of war, because its red colour reminded them of blood. That's why it is also known as the Red Planet.



Earth



Mars

An alternate Earth?

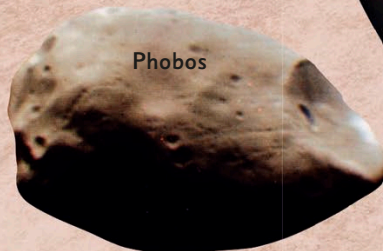
Mars is half the size of the Earth, and conditions are very different to those on our planet. Although Mars has a thin atmosphere and seasons, nothing grows there. Its red, desert-like surface is littered with dust and rocks.

I spy two moons

Mars has two lumpy moons that were discovered in 1877. They are so tiny that astronomers think they were asteroids pulled into orbit around Mars by its gravity.



Deimos (which means "terror" in Greek) is 16 km by 12 km (10 miles by 7 miles).



Phobos (which means "fear" in Greek) measures 28 km by 20 km (17 miles by 12 miles).

A Martian day – called a "sol" – lasts a little over 24 hours...